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[Main page](#)
[Contents](#)
[Featured content](#)
[Current events](#)
[Random article](#)
[Donate](#)

- ▼

Interaction

[Help](#)

[About Wikipedia](#)

[Community portal](#)

[Recent changes](#)

[Contact Wikipedia](#)
- Toolbox

[Print/export](#)

Article

Discussion

Read

Edit

View history





Pittsburgh, Fort Wayne and Chicago Railway

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The Pittsburgh, Fort Wayne and Chicago Railway was a major part of the [Pennsylvania Railroad](#) system, extending the PRR west from [Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania](#) via [Fort Wayne, Indiana](#) to [Chicago](#). It included the current [Fort Wayne Line](#) and [Fort Wayne Secondary](#).

Pittsburgh, Fort Wayne and Chicago Railway	
Locale	Pittsburgh, PA to Chicago
Dates of operation	1851–
Track gauge	4 ft 8 ¹ ⁄ ₂ in (1,435 mm) (standard gauge)

History [edit]

The Ohio and Pennsylvania Railroad was chartered in [Ohio](#) on February 24 and in [Pennsylvania](#) on April 11, 1848 to build from [Allegheny City, Pennsylvania](#) (annexed by [Pittsburgh](#) in 1907) west to [Crestline, Ohio](#) on the [Cleveland, Columbus and Cincinnati Railroad](#). It was organized on June 15, and construction began on July 4, 1849. The first section, from Allegheny City west to [New Brighton](#), opened July 30, 1851. Extensions opened to [Clarks Summit](#) on October 22 and [Enon Valley](#) November 19. On November 27, 1851 a section between [Salem](#) and [Alliance, Ohio](#) was completed, not yet connected to the rest. On December 8, the east section was extended west to [East Palestine, Ohio](#), with a [stagecoach](#) transfer provided for through travel. Further sections opened January 3, 1852 west to [Columbiana](#), and on January 6 the gap between Columbiana and Salem was filled. In conjunction with the [Cleveland and Pittsburgh Railroad](#), connecting at Alliance, a through line was provided between [Cleveland](#) and Pittsburgh. On March 11, 1852, an extension west to [Massillon](#) was opened with an excursion. On August 10, 1852 a further extension from Massillon west to [Wooster](#) opened. The line west to [Mansfield](#) was finished April 8, 1853, and the full line to [Crestline](#) opened April 11. With this it formed part of a through line to [Cincinnati](#) via the [Cleveland, Columbus and Cincinnati Railroad](#).

Work began on August 16, 1854 on the [Fort Wayne Railroad Bridge](#) over the [Allegheny River](#) to extend the O&P into [Pittsburgh](#) to connect with the [Pennsylvania Railroad](#). The bridge opened September 22, 1857, with a temporary station at [Penn Street](#) and [Tenth Street](#).



1850 map of the Ohio and Pennsylvania Railroad

The Ohio and Indiana Railroad was chartered in [Ohio](#) on March 26, 1850 and in [Indiana](#) on January 15, 1851, to extend the line west to [Fort Wayne, Indiana](#). It was organized July 4, 1850 and work began in February 1852. Some of the capital was gained from a merger with the Great Western Railroad of Ohio in 1851. On August 26, 1853 the line opened from [Crestline](#) west to [Bucyrus](#), and a continuation west to [Forest](#) opened in early January 1854. On June 10 the line opened west to [Delphos](#), and on October 31 the full line to Fort Wayne was completed, opening the next day.

The Fort Wayne and Chicago Railroad was chartered in [Indiana](#) on May 11, 1852 and organized September 14, 1852 as a further extension west to [Chicago](#). It was chartered February 5, 1853 in [Illinois](#). The first section opened in February 1856 from Fort Wayne to [Columbia City](#).

On July 26, 1856 the Pittsburgh, Fort Wayne and Chicago Rail Road was formed as a consolidation of the Fort Wayne and Chicago, Ohio and Indiana, and Ohio and Pennsylvania Railroads. Extensions opened west to [Warsaw](#) September 28, [Plymouth](#) November 10, [Englewood, Illinois](#) (south of [Chicago](#)) on November 29, 1858, and Van Buren Street in Chicago on December 25, 1858. On January 1, 1859 trains started running to Chicago, with a terminal at the future location of [Union Station](#). The part west of Plymouth was built with rails removed from the [New Portage Railroad](#).

From the early days, the [Pennsylvania Railroad](#) (PRR) had been involved with the project, supplying funds. Once the [Fort Wayne Railroad Bridge](#) at [Pittsburgh](#) was finished in 1857, trains began to run through from [Philadelphia](#). In 1858 the PFW&C began using the first [Union Station](#) in Pittsburgh, shared with the PRR.

On July 1, 1859 the PFW&C defaulted on its debts, and was sold at [foreclosure](#) on October 24, 1861. It was reorganized as the Pittsburgh, Fort Wayne and Chicago Railway February 26, 1862.

On July 1, 1865 the PFW&C leased the [New Castle and Beaver Valley Railroad](#), giving it a branch from [Homewood, Pennsylvania](#) north to [New Castle](#). The [Lawrence Railroad](#), branching west from [Lawrence Junction](#) on the NC&BV to [Youngstown, Ohio](#), was leased on June 27, 1869. On June 1, 1887 the Lawrence Railroad became part of the [Youngstown, Lawrence and Pittsburgh Railroad](#), which on August 1 merged into the PRR's [Pittsburgh, Youngstown and Ashtabula Railroad](#), and on January 9, 1906 that merged with the New Castle and Beaver Valley to form the [Pittsburgh, Youngstown and Ashtabula Railway](#), still leased to the PRR.

The PFW&C bought the [Cleveland, Zanesville and Cincinnati Railroad](#) by [deed](#) on July 1, 1865, making it its Akron Branch. The line ran from [Hudson, Ohio](#) on the [Cleveland and Pittsburgh Railroad](#) south through [Akron](#), crossing the PFW&C at [Orrville](#) and continuing to [Millersburg](#). In 1868 a short 3.5 mile (5.5 km) extension to the south was built, and on November 4, 1869 the PFW&C sold the line to the [Pittsburgh, Mt. Vernon, Columbus and London Railroad](#). That company later became part of the PRR's [Cleveland, Akron and Cincinnati Railway](#).

On May 22, 1869 the PFW&C leased the [Massillon and Cleveland Railroad](#), giving it a short branch from [Massillon](#) north to the Akron Branch at [Clinton](#).

On July 1, 1869 the PRR leased the PFW&C and began operating it directly, but on April 1, 1871 the PFW&C was transferred to the newly-formed [Pennsylvania Company](#). On December 1, 1871 the Pennsylvania Company leased the [Cleveland and Pittsburgh Railroad](#). Since January 25, 1860 the C&P had been operated jointly by itself and by the PFW&C, providing a branch of the PFW&C from [Rochester, Pennsylvania](#) west and north, crossing the PFW&C at [Alliance, Ohio](#) and continuing to [Cleveland](#).

Operation was transferred back to the [Pennsylvania Railroad](#) from the [Pennsylvania Company](#) on January 1, 1918.

On February 1, 1968 the PRR was merged into [Penn Central](#). The PFW&C stayed separate, filing for [bankruptcy](#) on July 14, 1973 after Penn Central's 1970 bankruptcy. On April 1, 1976 the PFW&C became part of [Conrail](#). Conrail downgraded the line, preferring other parallel lines. On June 2, 1994 the [Norfolk Southern Railway](#) bought 18 miles (29 km) from [Gary](#) to [Valparaiso](#), which had been out of service since 1991, for \$1.4 million. They soon bought 61 more miles (98 km), from Valparaiso east to [Warsaw](#), and acquired [trackage rights](#) east to [Fort Wayne](#).

With the August 22, 1998 breakup of Conrail, the line was split at [Crestline, Ohio](#). West of Crestline, including the section that had been owned by Norfolk Southern since 1994, went to [CSX Transportation](#), along with the intersecting [Cleveland, Cincinnati, Chicago and St. Louis Railway](#) (part of the [New York Central Railroad](#) system until 1968). East of Crestline went to Norfolk Southern, which also obtained [trackage rights](#) west of Crestline. At the west end, the line has been abandoned from [Buffington, Indiana](#) (in northwestern [Gary](#)) northwest to [Whiting, Indiana](#); at both locations there are connections to the parallel old [Lake Shore and Michigan Southern Railway](#) ([New York Central Railroad](#)). On the east side, the line is out of service west of [Tolleston](#), at the junction with the old [Michigan Central Railroad](#) (now CSX). On the other side of the gap, at [Whiting](#), the LS&MS disappears, and a connection goes back to the old PFW&C, which runs the rest of the way into Chicago, carrying both Norfolk Southern freight trains and several [Amtrak](#) passenger services.

On August 1, 2004 the [Chicago Fort Wayne and Eastern Railroad](#), a new [short line](#) owned by [RailAmerica](#), leased the west part of the line, from [Crestline, Ohio](#) west to [Tolleston, Indiana](#), from CSX. It also obtained [overhead trackage rights](#) along the formerly out-of-service line from Tolleston west to [Clarke Junction](#), and west along the former [Baltimore and Ohio Chicago Terminal Railroad](#) (now CSX) to [Blue Island, Illinois](#). [Norfolk Southern](#) continues to own the line east of Crestline, as well as the part west of [Whiting, Indiana](#).



ca. 1874 [Pennsylvania Railroad](#) map, including the PFW&C

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Categories: Companies affiliated with the Pennsylvania Railroad west of Pittsburgh | Defunct Pennsylvania railroads | Defunct Ohio railroads | Defunct Indiana railroads | Defunct Illinois railroads | Railroads in the Chicago Switching District | Railroads transferred to Conrail | Predecessors of the Pennsylvania Railroad | Railway companies established in 1860 | Railway companies disestablished in 1976 | Four foot ten inch gauge railways